

Sigel's failure

In the event, many of Sigel's men were still far down the Valley Turnpike, the only macadamized road in a sea of rain-churned muddy lanes. As the fighting surged back and forth over the pastures and knolls outside the town, the Union commander could only place what troops he did have along a ridge overlooking the fields and orchards of a farm belonging to the local Bushong family. There he also positioned 18 of his guns.

Breckinridge, who at Shiloh and Chickamauga had proved a remarkably fine soldier, led a Confederate assault that advanced up those boggy slopes. But as rain lashed the fields and the Union guns raked the attacking troops, a dangerous gap appeared in the Southern ranks. Before the Northern soldiers could seize the opportunity, Breckinridge called reluctantly for the cadets—"Put the boys in, and may God forgive me for the order"—to move up and plug the hole.

Dressed as if on parade, the lines of cadets crossed a plowed field that rain had made such a quagmire they lost their shoes in the mud. Passing through a field of green wheat, some of the youths were torn to pieces by canister (artillery shot used at close quarters). Continuing onward, their comrades wavered only when Union riflemen began piling volleys into them; many of them fell, but the remainder pressed forward and, sinking to their knees, reached their assigned place.

After a weak Union counterattack turned into a shambles, Sigel's artillerymen began limbering up their guns. The cadets then sprang to their feet and swept up the hill. A Union officer remembered it as the most "sublime" sight he ever witnessed in the war. The rest of the Confederate line rose in response and stormed the ridge, routing Sigel's men, who retreated pell-mell down the Valley Turnpike, not stopping for a day and a night. With them went Grant's hopes for a Shenandoah Valley offensive. Lee's flank was secured, and Breckinridge was able to march his small force east to reinforce the Army of Northern Virginia.